

ART 205 · DIGITAL PHOTOGRAPHY · PHOTOGRAPHER PRESENTATION

Henri Cartier-Bresson

the eye of the century

MARCO

THE LIFE

SHUN

THE WORK & THE RULES

ANDY

THE PHILOSOPHY & ONE PHOTO

press → to begin

94
years in the air.
He never lands.

Behind the Gare Saint-Lazare · Paris, 1932 · © Henri Cartier-Bresson /
Magnum Photos



1908 · 2004 · FRANCE

Henri Cartier-Bresson

Painter first. Photographer by accident. Co-founder of
Magnum Photos. The man who gave photography its most
famous idea: *the decisive moment*.

1

CAMERA

50

MM LENS

0

FLASH

0

CROPPING



Paris, 1954 · photo: Ihei Kimura (public domain)

The life. The rules. The moment.

01

The life

Painting, Surrealism, one photograph that changed everything, war, and Magnum.

02

The work & the rules

The Leica, the rules he never broke, and a contact sheet of his greatest pictures.

03

The philosophy & one photo

"The decisive moment", the critics, and a close reading of the puddle jump.

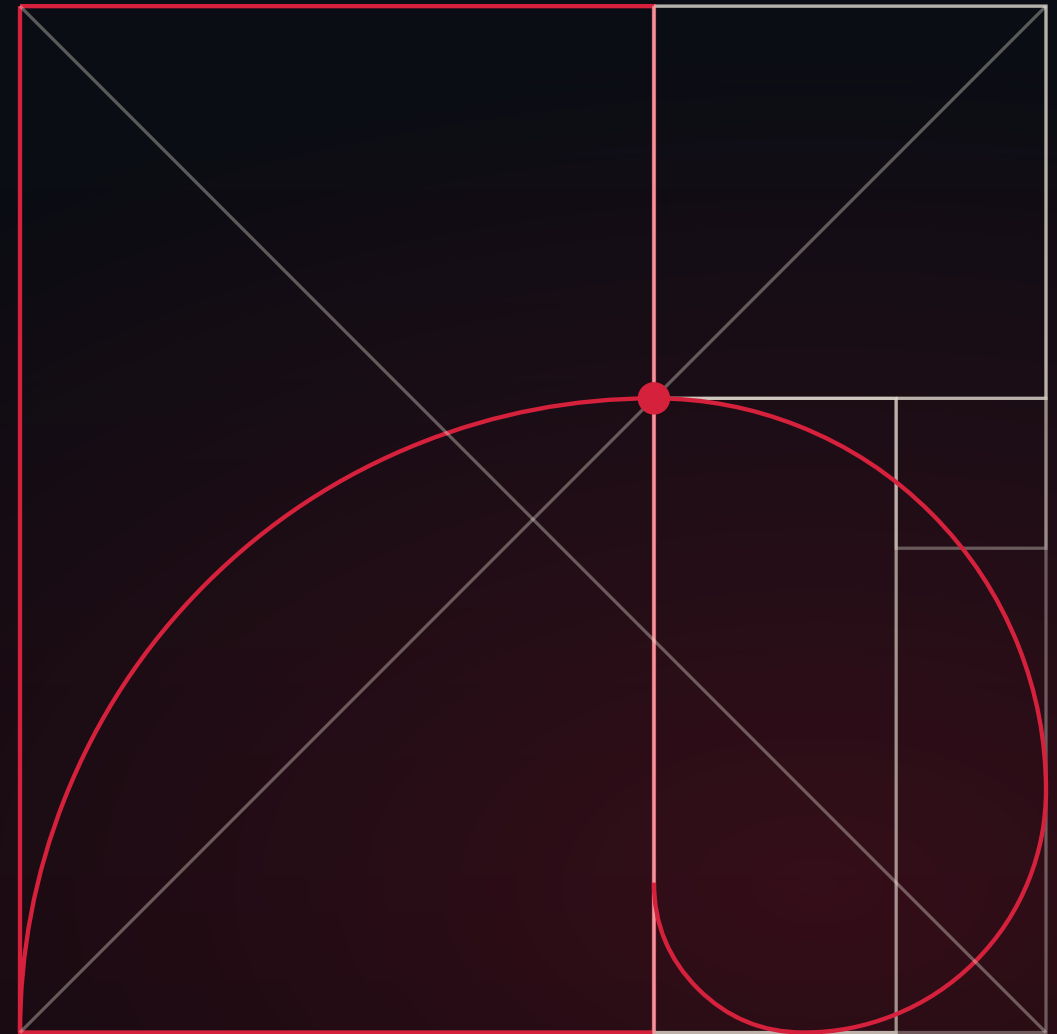
ORIGINS · 1908 – 1928

Before the camera, the *line*.

Born into a wealthy textile family. "Cartier-Bresson thread" was in every French sewing kit. Money gave him one thing: **freedom**.

At 18 he entered the studio of the Cubist painter André Lhote. Lhote taught him geometry: the golden section, balance, proportion. "For me he represented Cubism."

1928–29: Cambridge, literature and painting. He came back bilingual, and still a painter.





INFLUENCE · SURREALISM

Chance is the *teacher*.

In the late 1920s he sat in the cafés of André Breton's Surrealist circle. Their lesson: walk the street, trust the unconscious, wait for the strange coincidence.

Look at Brussels, 1932: two men, one peeking, one watching us. Humour, mystery, no explanation. Pure Surrealism, with a camera.

Brussels, 1932 · © Henri Cartier-Bresson / Magnum Photos

THE TURNING POINT · 1931

One photograph changed his life.

1930–31: a year in the Ivory Coast, hunting; he nearly died of fever. Back in France he saw this picture by Martin Munkácsi: three boys running into Lake Tanganyika.

"I suddenly understood that photography can *fix eternity in a moment*."

HENRI CARTIER-BRESSON

1932: he bought a **Leica**. He put the brushes down for forty years.



Martin Munkácsi · Three Boys at Lake Tanganyika, c. 1930 · © Estate of Martin Munkácsi



EARLY WORK • 1932 – 1935

The painter's eye, at *1/100 s.*

Hyères, 1932. The staircase curls like a spiral; the cyclist is a blur of motion. Lhote's geometry + Surrealist chance = a new kind of picture.

He travelled France, Spain, Italy, Mexico. 1933: first solo show, Julien Levy Gallery, New York. 1935: exhibition with Álvarez Bravo in Mexico City. He was 27.

Hyères, France, 1932 • © Henri Cartier-Bresson / Magnum Photos

CINEMA & WAR · 1936 – 1946

Declared dead. Came back.

1936–39: assistant to film director Jean Renoir. 1940: captured by the Germans: 35 months as a prisoner of war. Escaped on his third attempt, 1943.

1945, Dessau: a Gestapo informer is recognised by a woman she denounced. One frame, and the whole war is in it.

1947: MoMA New York planned a *posthumous* exhibition. They thought he had died in the war. He showed up to the opening.



Dessau, Germany, April 1945 · © Henri Cartier-Bresson / Magnum Photos

MAGNUM & THE WORLD · 1947 – 2004

The eye of the *century*.

1947: he co-founds Magnum Photos with Robert Capa, "Chim" Seymour, George Rodger and William Vandivert. He takes Asia, and he is there when history happens.



1947

Co-founds Magnum Photos



1948

India: photographs Gandhi 90 minutes before his assassination, then the funeral, for *Life*



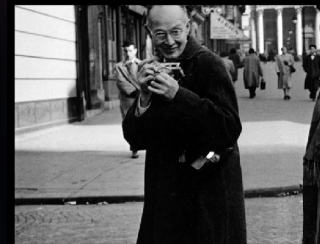
1948–49

China: the fall of the Kuomintang, the Shanghai gold rush



1952

The Decisive Moment published, cover by Matisse



1954

First Western photographer in the USSR after Stalin



1970s

Leaves Magnum's daily work, returns to drawing



2003

Fondation HCB opens in Paris



2004

Dies in Provence, aged 95

PART TWO

The work & the *rules*.

How he shot, and what he shot.

Less equipment, *more eye.*

01

One Leica, one 50 mm

A small 35 mm rangefinder with a "normal" lens, the same angle as the human eye. He wrapped the shiny chrome in black tape so nobody noticed him.

Britannica · Fondation HCB · Wikipedia (Van Riper, 2002)

02

No flash. Ever.

"Impolite... like coming to a concert with a pistol in your hand." Only available light, so exposure depends on reading the scene fast.

HCB, quoted by F. Van Riper, Washington Post 2002

03

No cropping

"If you start cutting or cropping a good photograph, it means death to the geometrically correct interplay of proportions." The black border on his prints proves the full frame.

The Decisive Moment, 1952 preface

04

No darkroom

After 1950 a Paris lab made virtually all his prints. He wanted his energy in the street, not in chemicals. The picture was finished when the shutter closed.

Art Institute of Chicago

05

Black & white

Almost never colour. Without colour you see what he saw: light, line, shape, texture, tonal contrast.

AP / NBC News obituary, 2004

06

Geometry first

"The only pair of compasses at the photographer's disposal is his own pair of eyes." Find the structure, then wait for life to enter it.

The Decisive Moment, 1952 preface



COMPOSITION STUDY ·
SEVILLE, 1933

Children in the ruins

A Framing

The broken wall is a frame within the frame.
The ruin becomes a stage.

B Depth & proportion

Rough wall in front, tiny children behind: the
eye travels into deep space.

C Texture

Crumbling plaster against soft skin: the tactile
contrast of B&W.

D Light & tone

Hard Spanish sun: bright whites, deep blacks,
no grey middle.

FRAMING

DEPTH OF FIELD

PROPORTION

TEXTURE

TONAL CONTRAST

THE BODY OF WORK · 1933 — 1969 · CLICK A FRAME

A contact sheet of the *20th century*.



Coronation of King George VI

1937



Gold Rush

December 1948



Women praying on the hill

1948



Rue Mouffetard

1954



Alberto Giacometti

1961



Henri Matisse

February 1944



Sunday on the Banks of the Marne

1938



Children in a circle

1969

A CURATOR'S MAP · CLÉMENT CHÉROUX, CENTRE POMPIDOU, 2014

"Not one, but *several* Cartier-Bressons."

1926 – 1935

The Surrealist

Chance, dreams, geometry. Hyères, Seville, Brussels. Pictures with no story, only mystery and form.

1936 – 1946

The engaged witness

Communist newspapers, Renoir's films, the Coronation crowd, the war, Dessau. The camera turns political.

1947 – 1970s

The Magnum eye · then the contemplative

Gandhi, China, Moscow, Paris streets. Later: quiet landscapes, portraits, and a return to drawing.

PART THREE

The *decisive* moment.

A philosophy, and one photograph up close.

ARTIST STATEMENT · 1952

Images on the *sly*.

His book *Images à la sauvette*, "images taken on the sly", like a street seller ready to run from the police. 126 photographs, cover by Matisse.

The American publisher wanted a stronger title. He picked a line from the epigraph, a 17th-century cardinal: "*There is nothing in this world that does not have a decisive moment.*"

The English title became the most famous idea in photography.



“

To me, photography is the *simultaneous recognition*, in a *fraction of a second*, of the *significance of an event* as well as of a *precise organization of forms* which give that event its proper expression.

HENRI CARTIER-BRESSON · THE DECISIVE MOMENT, 1952

HALF ONE

Meaning

Something is *happening*: a jump, a look, a gesture. The significance of the event.

HALF TWO

Geometry

At the same instant, the forms fall into place: line, balance, rhythm. The organization of forms.

IN HIS OWN WORDS · 1973 · 90 SECONDS

VIDEO · "The Decisive Moment", HCB narrates, 1973 (ICP film)

youtube.com/watch?v=dlUWznm1ufU · backup: youtube.com/watch?v=14ih3Wge0Ls (0:00–1:30)

[Open on YouTube ↗](#) · backup: [1973 film, 0:00–1:30 ↗](#)

INTERVIEWS · 1979 – 2000

Looking is *everything*.

“

Photographing is nothing. Looking is everything.

HCB · LE FIGARO MAGAZINE, 1989

“

I don't take the photograph. The photograph takes me.

HCB · CHARLIE ROSE INTERVIEW, 2000

“

Photography is not a meditation. It's something intuitive. Drawing is a form of meditation.

HCB · NEW YORK REVIEW OF BOOKS, 1995

Late in life he wrote in a friend's copy of the book: "*The More or Less Decisive Moments*." He never took his own myth too seriously.

WHAT THE ART WORLD SAYS

Critics & *curators*

“

The decisive part of Cartier-Bresson's particular process takes place not in the mechanism in his hand but in the vision in his head.

LINCOLN KIRSTEIN · MOMA CATALOGUE, 1947

“

He was one of the most talented photographers ever at making very clear, simple pictures, classically organized, almost like a painting from the 17th century.

PETER GALASSI · CURATOR, MOMA "THE MODERN CENTURY", 2010

“

You will be labelled the little surrealist photographer... Continue on your way, but with the label of photojournalist, and keep the rest deep in your heart.

ROBERT CAPA · ADVICE TO HCB, 1947

“

Only one man had the discerning eye and the lightning reflexes to capture again and again and again what he called "the decisive moment".

MALCOLM JONES · NEWSWEEK OBITUARY, 2004

ONE PHOTO, UP CLOSE · 1932

Behind the Gare Saint-Lazare

1 Timing

The heel is a centimetre from the water. A fast shutter freezes the leap, the moment *before*.

2 Reflection · symmetry

Still water = a mirror. The man and his double share one axis: perfect balance.

3 Visual echo

On the wall, a poster dancer makes the same leap, reversed. He noticed it only afterwards.

4 Line & rhyme

The ladder in the water reads like railway tracks. We are behind a train station, under a poster that spells "RAILOWSKY".

5 Rhythm

Barrel hoops in the water anticipate the ripples that will come. Repetition of circles.

6 The exception

Shot through a gap in a fence too narrow for the lens. So the man who never cropped... cropped this one.

SHUTTER SPEED

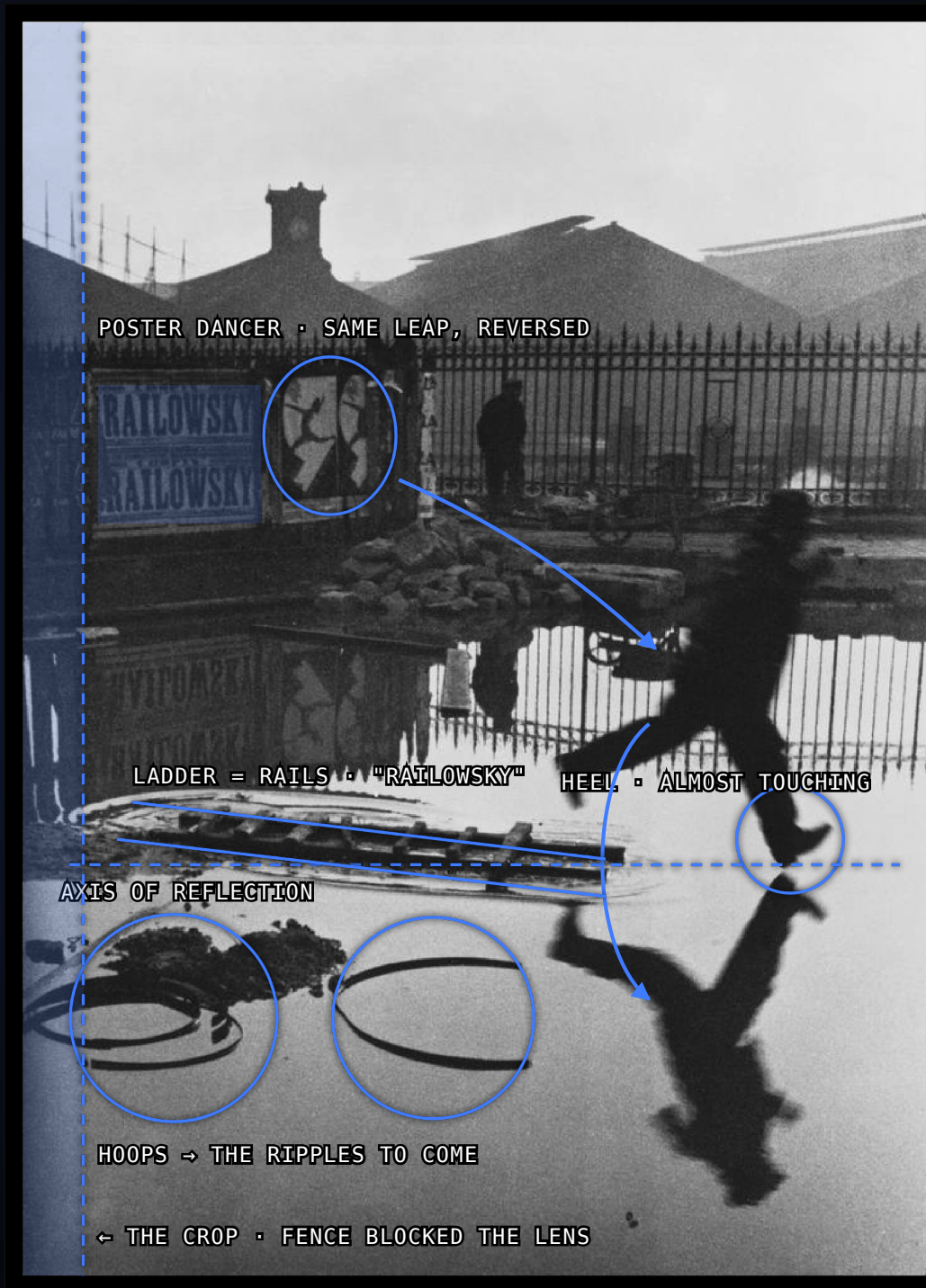
SILHOUETTE · SHAPE

SYMMETRY · BALANCE

LINE

RHYTHM

SHALLOW SPACE



Behind the Gare Saint-Lazare, Paris, 1932 · © Henri Cartier-Bresson / Magnum Photos · MoMA

The decisive moment is not luck.
It is being *ready* when luck arrives.

OUR READING OF BEHIND THE GARE SAINT-LAZARE

TIME 100

Named one of the 100 most influential photographs ever made.

\$590,455

A print sold at Christie's, New York, in 2011.

Every phone

Every street photographer since, and every one of us waiting for the right instant, is in his debt.



He's still in the air.

Thank you · Marco · Shun · Andy · ART 205 · questions?



SCAN FOR THE SLIDES
& THE HANDOUT (PDF)

RESOURCES

Sources & image credits

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IMAGES

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